of 18 November 1950. India's policy in Tibet was to be determined by two factors: first, the need to look at Tibet in the larger context of relations with the People's Republic of China, which was now firmly entrenched in Beijing; and the recognition that India did not have the capacity or capability to assist Tibet to militarily resist a Chinese takeover. [19] These were reasonable presumptions, but the conclusion was that Tibet could not be saved and, therefore, the 'real protection we (India) should seek is some kind of understanding with China' that can help Tibet retain a large measure of autonomy. [20] Patel's advice had been to review the entire approach and to open discussions with China on problem areas, including the boundary, but this was not heeded. Instead, throughout 1950, India decided to keep its counsel, and to be helpful to the Chinese in the hope of earning goodwill. This might also explain the actions that India took with respect to Zhou Enlai's requests about not allowing the Dalai Lama to seek sanctuary in India and about dissuading Nepal from pursuing a military option in Tibet. These two tactical cards available to India were surrendered in the hope that it could convince China about its good intentions and help preserve a measure of Tibetan independence as well as its own interests in Tibet.

The 17-Point Agreement in May 1951 ought to have been another occasion for the Government of India to review its approach on the Tibet Question. But it had been decided that the Tibet issue would not be raised with China. Hence India foreclosed on the option of learning the implications for India about the Agreement directly from the Chinese. The 17-Point Agreement had been explicit in stating that Tibet was a part of China and that the Tibetan government was only a local government with no authority over its own foreign affairs and defence. India clutched at straws instead. It drew the inference from Clause 3 that Tibet would retain its autonomy, and from